



A PROPOSAL TO THE PAONIA PLANNING COMMISSION · CHAPTER 16, ARTICLE 6

Fixing Paonia's Parking Code

*The Mancos-Ouray model: keep residential
parking, free up downtown.*

PETE MCCARTHY · PAONIA RESIDENT

THE PROBLEM

One business after another, stalled at the same wall.

- The Learning Council
- CIRC
- Blue Sage
- The bookstore, going through it right now

Every one of them ran into the same off-street parking rule on the 200 and 300 blocks of Grand Avenue. Buildings built before the car, that the code now makes hard and expensive to reuse.



WHAT OUR CODE ACTUALLY REQUIRES TODAY

It was last touched in 2015. It shows.

- Sets parking by bedroom count (a commissioner called it "really antiquated").
- Lists requirements for hospitals and high schools we do not have.
- An undefined "construction, addition or change of use" trigger nobody can read; the thing that snagged the bookstore.
- A 300-foot off-site parking rule the Commission called "just old."
- Orders businesses to pay into a "Parking Fund" suspended since 2015, and points to the wrong section number, so it does not even function.



THE COST NO ONE SEES

Parking minimums quietly tax every new business and home.

\$5-50k

to build a single parking space

\$200-500

per month added to rent, per space (State of
Colorado finding)

*C.R.S. § 29-36-101 (Colorado legislative findings,
2024). Minimums "put small businesses at a
disadvantage relative to large corporations."*

WHY IT MATTERS

THIS IS NOT A BIG-CITY IDEA

Small towns lead this reform, not big cities.

Roughly 40% of all U.S. towns that have removed parking minimums are under 25,000 people. Colorado towns smaller than Paonia did it years ago and have lived with it just fine.

And it is already our own plan.

Our 2024 Comprehensive Plan, Policy ECON-3, calls to "create and maintain a healthy, vibrant, and beautiful economic downtown corridor on and around Grand Avenue." This is how we get there.

SMALL COLORADO TOWNS THAT ALREADY DID IT

And we can quote their adopted code, word for word.

Town	Pop.	Downtown	Residential	ADU
Mancos (near us)	~1,200	none required	kept (2/home)	1 space, waivable
Ouray	~900	none on Main	kept (2/home)	1 space
Del Norte	~1,460	exempt	kept	—
Wray	~2,360	none required	kept	—
Dolores	~885	none + small-use exempt	kept	—

Mancos: "New development within the Downtown Center is not required to provide off-street parking or loading." Ouray: no off-street parking required for the buildings fronting U.S. Highway 550 through downtown.



LOOKING AHEAD: ADUS

A casita, not a parking pad.

Paonia does not regulate ADUs yet, so this proposal does not touch them. But that code is coming, and the parking question comes with it.

If an old-style minimum rides along, every casita has to dig up green space for cars. Mancos asks for just one space, easily waived when there is street parking. A recommendation for that future code rides with the draft, so we get it right before it starts.

THE MANCOS-OURAY MODEL FOR PAONIA

Three changes. Nothing else moves.

- No off-street parking required for businesses, anywhere in town. The old commercial table (with its hospitals and high schools) is gone.
- None at all in the C-1 downtown core, the way Mancos and Ouray do it (homes and lodging keep one space).
- Ordinary residential parking kept, and on-street parking counts toward it.
- Plus: repeal the dead Parking Fund, and keep ADA and design standards.

Single-family neighborhoods keep their parking exactly as they are. ADUs are handled separately, as a recommendation for the code that is coming. We are not getting rid of parking; we are fixing what is broken.

WHAT STAYS THE SAME

- Accessible (ADA) parking: fully kept.
- Single-family and two-family homes: 2 spaces, unchanged.
- Nobody is barred from building parking. It is just no longer forced where it does harm.
- Grand Avenue on-street parking stays for visitors.

The 2025 downtown survey found businesses are already satisfied with parking availability. We have two town lots and plenty of parking. The Commission said so itself.



NO PARKING APOCALYPSE

"New development within the
Downtown Center is not required
to provide off-street parking or
loading."

*Town of Mancos, Colorado, municipal code (§16-8-2,
Ordinance 751). A town of about 1,200, one valley over.
Adopted in 2019 and still on the books. Empty buildings
got reused; downtown did not run out of parking.*

WHAT WE GET INSTEAD



THE ASK

Let's lead the North Fork valley.

- Take up the draft Article 6 in the packet as the Commission's starting point.
- Adopt the Mancos-Ouray model and recommend it to the Trustees.
- Repeal the suspended Parking Fund while we are at it.

Hotchkiss, Crawford, and Cedaredge have not done this.
Paonia can be the town that did.